Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**



THE **TEMPTATION TO BE A FREE RIDER** ON AMERICAN GEOPOLITICAL PRESSURE ON CHINA **LOOKS EASY AND APPEARS COSTLESS**

This temptation to be a free rider on American geopolitical pressure on China is understandable. It looks like an easy option, with no visible costs. However, any objective audit of the pros and cons of becoming an ally, implicitly or explicitly, of the US will show that in doing so, India would have forsaken an even bigger geopolitical opportunity to become a truly independent third pole in the global order. And the world is crying out for an independent third pole to turn to.

Just look at the situation of the 54 countries in Africa. Many of the African leaders who joined the White House meeting with US President Joe Biden on December 14, 2022, must have been delighted by this flattering invitation. But if any of them thought that this was the result of the US discovering the intrinsic worth and beauty of Africa, they would only be deluding themselves. Most African leaders are shrewd enough to know that this White House invitation was